Data Quality - Notes

Nils Rechberger

2026-02-09

Lecture 01: Introduction

Relevance of Data Quality

A key advance in data quality emerged in the 1920s through R. A. Fisher's work in experimental design, which introduced randomization and replication to estimate error, bias, and precision.

Definitions

Data

Data are abstract representations of selected features of real-world entities, events, and concepts, expressed and understood through clearly definable conventions (Sebastian-Coleman, 2013).

Data Quality

- Contextual data quality: The quality of data is defined by two related factors: how well it meets the expectations of data consumers (how well it is able to serve the purposes of its intended use).
- Intrinsic data quality: How well it represents the objects, events, and concepts it is created to represent.

Data Management

DQ as part of Data Management

Data Governance sits at the center (the hub) because it provides oversight, direction, policies, and coordination. Data quality is but one element of effective data management.

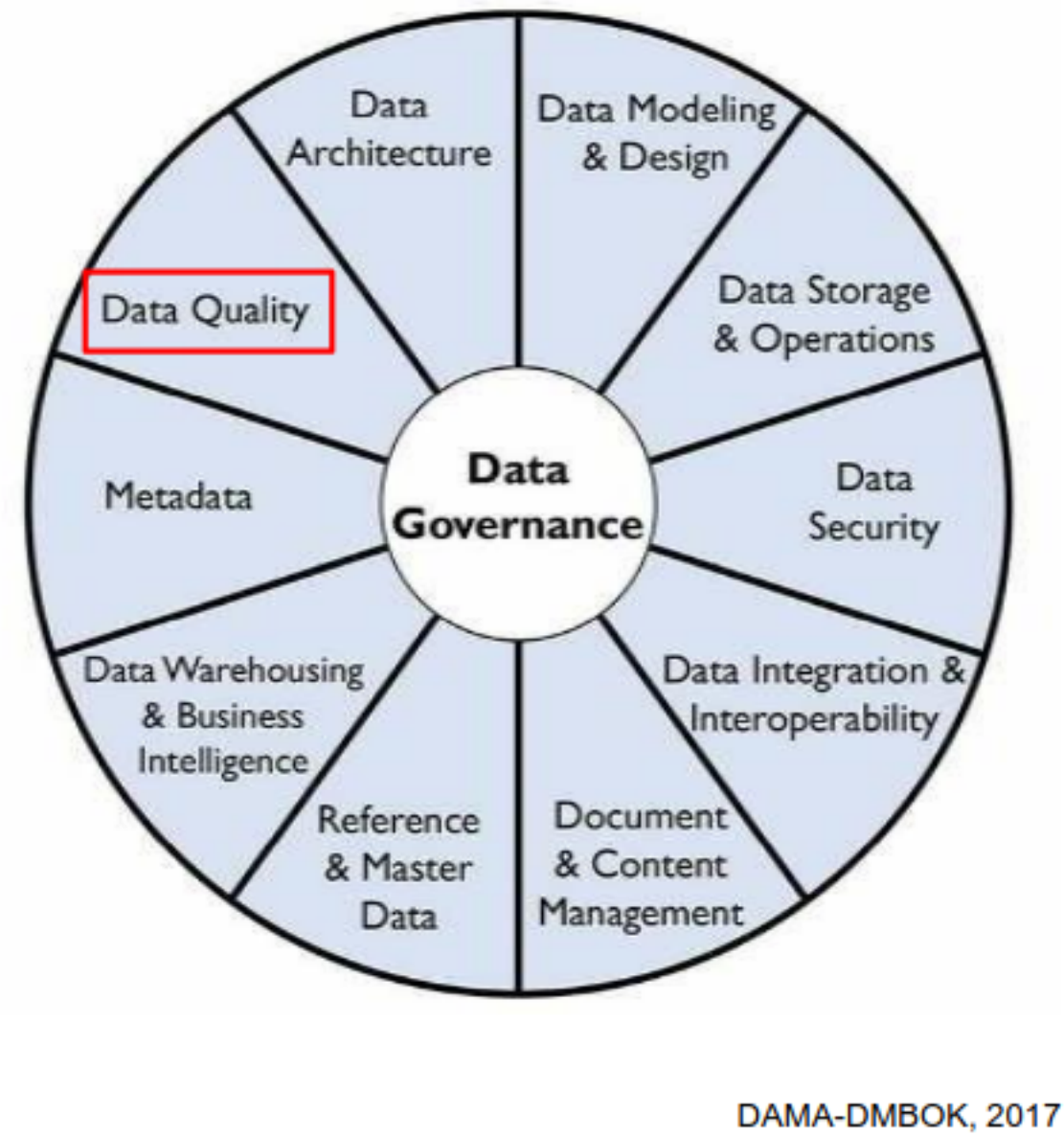

Figure 1: Data Management

Role of Data Quality Managers

- Develop a governed approach to make data fit for purpose based on data consumers requirements.
- Define standards, requirements, and specifications for data quality controls as part of the data lifecycle.
- Define and implement processes to measure, monitor, and report on data quality levels.
- Identify and advocate for opportunities to improve the quality of data, through process and system improvements.

Data Quality Dimensions

- Correctness/accuracy: The data accurately describe the entity in question
- Completeness: No missing records/field values
- Conformity/validity: Correct types, value ranges, etc.
- Consistency: No contradictions between different data sets / tables

  Note: Breaking the issue down into dimensions helps to quantify issues.

> **Note**
>
> Most sources agree that the concept of data quality has several dimensions. But they don't agree on what these dimensions are.

Lecutre 02: Data Quality Dimensions

In order to measure a broad concept such as data quality, it needs to be broken down into measurable, actionable dimensions. Each dimension captures one measurable aspect of data quality. Measuring data quality serves to analyze/understand/resolve or minimize data quality problems.

Note: Some of the dimensions are objective/quantitative or subjective/qualitative.

Classification of Dimensions

Objective vs. subjective measurement

- Objective: Verifiable by rules, counts, constraints, timestamps, or comparisons. Independent of user perception.
- Subjective: Depends on human judgment, expectations, or context of use.

Data value (intrinsic) vs. usage-dependent (contextual)

- Data value: Intrinsic quality of the dataset itself. Affects correctness, analytical validity, and downstream results even if usage is unknown. E.g. completeness, consistency
- Usage: Quality emerges only in interaction with users, systems, or tasks. Context-dependent.

Popular Dimensions

Quantitative and intrinsic dimensions

- Completeness: No missing records/field values
- Correctness/accuracy: The data accurately describe the entity in question
- Conformance/validity: Correct types, value ranges, etc.

Quantitative and contextual dimension

- Consistency: No contradictions between different data sets / tables
- Currency: the data are up to date

Completeness

Completeness is the most fundamental dimension. It simply measures whether data are present or absent. Analysis may be limited to critical/mandatory attributes. Measurement:

- at the field level (per column)
- at the record level (how many rows have any missing fields)
- at the table level (how many records are missing)

  Note: The completeness can be calculated as a percentage at the field, record and table levels.

> **Note**
>
> Not all missingness indicates a data quality problem. To record (and therefore measure) qualified missingness in a database, one can use special sentinel values (e.g., `-9999` for numeric attributes, `NA` for text attributes)

Correctness/accuracy

It measures the extent to which data are the true representation of reality. Measurement:

- at the field
- at record level

Conformance / Validity

Conformity (or validity) means compliance of the data with a set of standards, e.g., in terms of:

- Type ("Name" is a string; "Number of children" is an integer)
- Range ("Contractual work hours" is between 0 and 50)
- Format ("Date" in ISO format YYYY-MM-DD, "Email" me{at}example.com)
- Value from a reference list ("CH", "DE", …)

  Note: But even fully conformant data can be 100% inaccurate.

Role of Representation

Besides conformance/validity, another prerequisite of correctness/accuracy is correct representation.

> Caution
>
> - **December 13, 1941** -> invalid
> - **1941-13-12** -> valid entry, but wrong representation
> - **1941-12-13** -> valid, correct representation correct/ accurate (provided the information is intrinsically accurate)

Role of Metadata

Metadata are data about data. Without metadata, it can be difficult to make sense of data. High quality metadata is important for representational effectiveness. Standard database metadata includes:

- Table/ column names and definitions
- Data types and domains of values
- Whether columns can have NULL values
- Rules regarding data relationships
- Cardinality (Number of unique values compared to the total rows, e.g. gender, boolean flags)

Lecture 03: Exploratory Data Analysis

Data Preparation

The process of manipulating data before analysis is referred to as data preparation. The meaning of the term data preparation depends on Point of view, Roles, Intended data use.

Point of view

The meaning of data preparation varies depending on one's position in the hierarchy.

> Note: We take a statistical view and focus on the EXPLORE/TRANSFORM level.

Role and intended data use

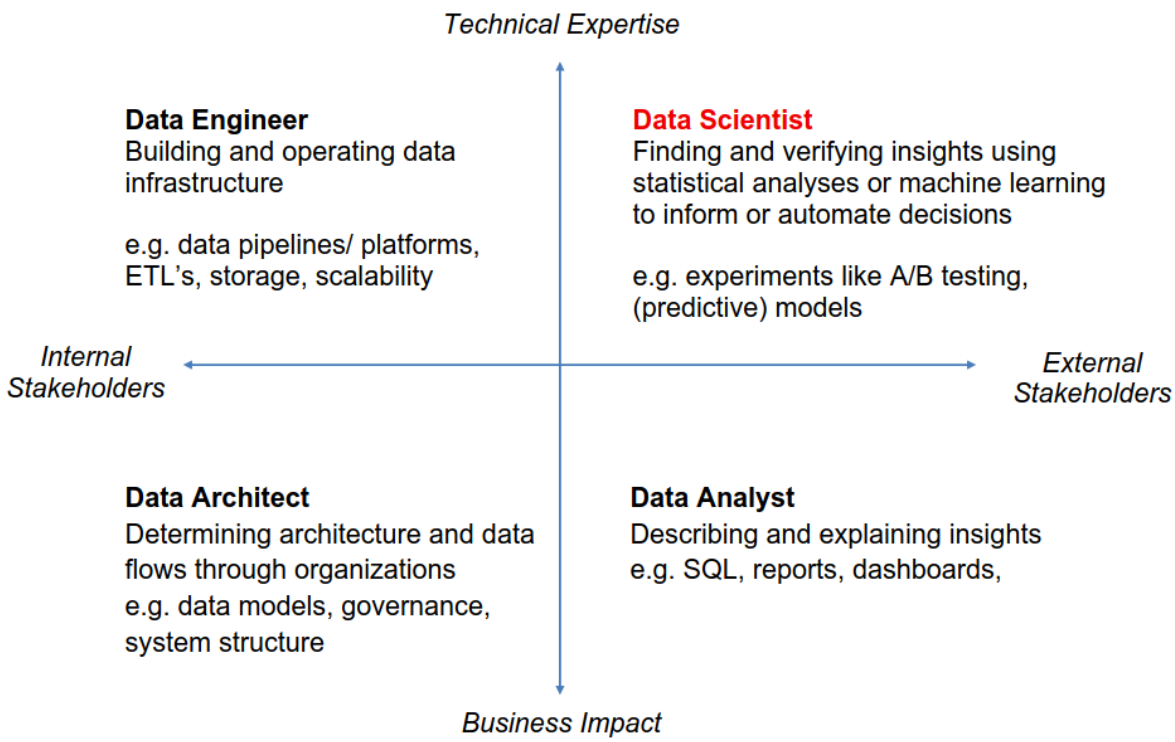

Figure 2: Role and intended data use

From Data to Understanding

The process from data to understanding is often described to as a cycle

"Data Wrangling is the ability to take a messy, unrefined source of data and wrangle it into something useful. It's the art of using computer programming to extract raw data and creating clear and actionable bits of information for your analysis. Data wrangling is the entire front end of the analytic process and requires numerous tasks that can be categorized within the get, clean, and transform components." (Bradley Boehmke)

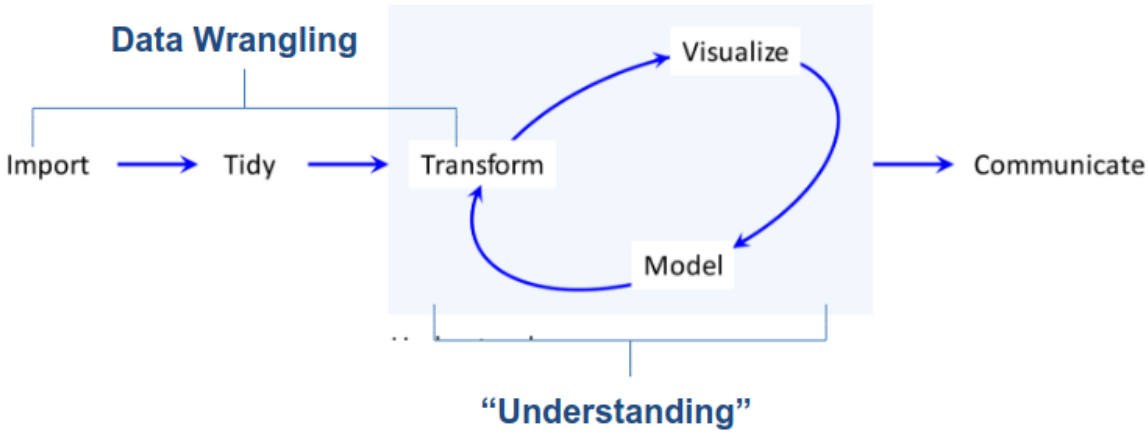

Figure 3: Data understanding cycle

Exploratory Data Analysis (EDA)

> **Tip**
>
> Always plot your data first.

Raw Approach:

- Examine the data before applying a specific probability model
- Focus on descriptive analysis over hypothesis testing
- Methods of graphical data analysis

Iterative cycle:

- Generate questions about your data.
- Search for answers by transforming, visualizing, and modeling your data.

Steps in the EDA Process

Identify data attributes. Determine measurement scales

		Possible statements	Example
Categorical → non-metric; qualitative	**Nominal**	Equality (=) Inequality (≠)	**Sex** male = 0, female = 1 female = female, male = male , male ≠ female
	Ordinal	In addition: Relation smaller (<) Relation larger (>)	**Attitude to health** Very bad = 1 to very good = 5 (=> 1 < 2 < 3 < 4 < 5) *Very good* is neither five times better than *very bad* nor does *very good* have a distance of 4 to *very bad*
Metric → metric, cardinal scaled; quantitative (discrete or continuous)	**Interval**	In addition: Comparison of differences	**Body temperature in °C** Difference 40° - 35° = 5° = difference 35° - 30° But a temperature of 10° is not twice as warm as 5°. Fahrenheit scale: 10° C = 50° F, 5° C = 41° F
	Ratio	In addition: Comparison of ratios	**Height**: 200 cm is twice as tall as 100 cm. There is a true zero point in this scale: 0 cm

Figure 4: Hierarchy of Scales

Univariate data analysis. Recognize basic properties of the data (e.g. boxplot)

Goal: Recognize basic properties of the data.

Description of central tendency:

- Arithmetic mean → Very sensitive to outliers
- Median → Splits data in half (25% smaller, 75% larger) → More robust to outliers than mean

Description of variability/ dispersion:

- Empirical variance
- Empirical standard deviation
- 1st quartile/ 25th percentile → 25% smaller, 75% larger.
- 3rd quartile/ 75th percentile → 75% smaller, 25% larger.
- Interquartile range (IQR) = 3rd quartile – 1st quartile → More robust than standard deviation

Bivariate & Multivariate data analysis. Recognize interactions in the data

Goal: Using bivariate & multivariate data analysis to recognize interactions in the data by using Plots and hypothesis tests.

Typical graphical procedures: - Scatterplot - Mosaic Plot

Typical tests: - Pearson Chi-Square test

Following EDA steps

- Detect aberrant & missing values. Analysis & adjustment
- Outlier detection. Analysis & cleaning
- Create derived variables (index, etc.) & Variable transformation